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UAE ranks 1st globally for international trade

DUBAI

Gulf News Report

The UAE ranked first globally for both international trade and economic performance in the IMD World Competitiveness Yearbook 2026, reinforcing its position as the Gulf's most competitive economy, according to data released by the GCC Statistical Center (GCC-Stat).

The rankings, compiled by the International Institute for Management Development (IMD), showed GCC countries achieving strong performances across key measures of economic, government and infrastructure competitiveness.

The UAE topped the International Trade indicator and the broader Economic Performance factor, reflecting the strength of its trade openness and economic competitiveness.

Other GCC rankings

Qatar ranked second globally in the Labour Market indicator under the Business Efficiency factor, while Bahrain placed third worldwide in Price Stability, highlighting the effectiveness of its economic policies.

Saudi Arabia ranked third globally in Basic Infrastructure, reflecting continued investment in projects supporting long-term growth. Kuwait secured third place in Public Finance under the Government Efficiency factor, while Oman ranked sixth globally in Tax Policy, reflecting the competitiveness of its fiscal framework.

SEE ALSO P-III

UAE STRONGLY CONDEMNS ISRAELI SETTLER ATTACKS IN THE WEST BANK

MoFA: Inaction risks deepening hatred and instability

DUBAI

Gulf News Report

The UAE has condemned in the strongest terms the attacks carried out by Israeli settlers against villages in the occupied West Bank, the latest of which involved setting fire to a mosque in Tulkarm.

The UAE affirmed that this constitutes a provocative act, an incitement against Muslims, and an act of extremism.

In a statement, the Ministry of Foreign Affairs (MoFA) warned against the continuous assaults by settlers, and called on the Israeli government to assume full responsibility, condemn these practices, and hold the perpetrators accountable.

The UAE stressed that failure to act will be seen as tacit approval that will only further deepen the cycle of hatred, racism, and instability.

Fulfil responsibilities

The Ministry called on the international community to fulfil its responsibilities to end the ongoing Israeli violations and to prevent aggravating the situation in the Occupied Palestinian Territory and the region.

The Ministry stressed the need to support all regional and international efforts to advance the peace process in the Middle East to reach comprehensive and just peace, as well as end illegal practices that undermine the two-state solution.



Ahmed Abu Mahmoud, 64, sits at the entrance of a mosque that was burned during an attack by Israeli settlers early in the morning in the West Bank village of Qusra, Sunday.

Earlier, Palestinian President Mahmoud Abbas appealed to world leaders and international bodies for urgent action to halt what he described as escalating Israeli military operations and settler violence against Palestinians in the occupied West Bank, including East Jerusalem.

In letters sent Sunday and uploaded early yesterday, Abbas urged Arab and friendly nations, the European Union, the Arab League and the UN Security Council president to inter-

vene amid a "dangerous escalation". The statement accuses Israeli forces and armed settler groups of attacks resulting in civilian casualties, destruction of homes, religious sites, agricultural land and property. It claims these actions occur with the support of the Israeli military and government.

Deadly clashes

Palestinian officials said Israeli settlers set fire to two mosques in the occupied West Bank overnight Sunday, after

deadly clashes in the territory left six people dead this week. Abdel Azim Wadi, mayor of the town of Qusra, south of Nablus, told AFP that settlers torched a mosque under construction in the southern part of the town.

"The fire destroyed the mosque's entrance and even damaged its stonework," Wadi said.

He added that the attackers spray-painted Hebrew graffiti on the mosque's walls, including the word "revenge".

SEE ALSO P6

Mediators see progress in diplomatic efforts to halt all-out war in Middle East

Qatar, Pakistan-led mediation brings pause in US-Iran strikes amid war fears

DUBAI

Gulf News Report

Mediators have achieved progress in efforts to get the United States and Iran back to negotiations and avert an all-out war in the Middle East, two regional officials said yesterday, with a pause in attacks coming after a period of rapidly escalating tensions.

The comments came after neither the US nor Iran reported carrying out any attacks for three straight days — a respite after about two weeks of sustained bombardments that had led to increasing fears of a return to all-out war.

The two regional officials, who spoke on condition of anonymity to discuss the sensitive regional talks, said mediators led by Qatar and Pakistan were working to bridge the gap between Washington and Tehran to return to an interim ceasefire

OIL SLIDES, STOCKS RISE AS TENSIONS EASE

Oil prices reversed course from a week ago, when a sharp escalation in fighting between the US and Iran worsened worries about global oil supplies. The price of Brent crude, the international standard, dropped 5.4 per cent to \$86.74 a barrel. Prices had surged to over \$100 a barrel last week.

Global stock markets rose as easing US-Iran tensions lifted investor sentiment. Wall Street opened higher, while European shares advanced, with Frankfurt leading gains. Asian markets also closed broadly higher.

"In what is likely to be one of the most important weeks of the year, the significant decline in oil prices reflect traders unwinding part of the geopolitical risk premium that had pushed Brent above \$100 a barrel," said Daniela Hathorn, Senior Market Analyst, capital.com. "That said, the situation remains far from resolved. Shipping risks through the Strait of Hormuz and the Red Sea mean markets remain vulnerable to fresh headlines, and any setback in negotiations could quickly send crude prices higher once again."

—Gulf News Report

deal that had been largely undermined by recent exchanges of fire.

No negotiations on currently

Iran's foreign ministry, however, said yesterday it was not currently involved in negotiations with the United States. "At present, we are not engaged in any negotiations with the United States," said the

ministry's spokesman Esmail Baqaei at a weekly press briefing, denying reports that Iran had requested talks.

Meanwhile, Saudi Arabia's Ministry of Defence said its air defence forces intercepted and destroyed several drones yesterday after they attempted to target oil facilities in the Kingdom's Eastern Province and the Riyadh region.

The ministry's official spokesperson, Major General Turki Al Malki, said the attempted attacks were launched from Iraqi territory by Iranian-backed militias.

Right to respond

Al Malki said Saudi Arabia has the legitimate right to defend its territory, its people and its critical infrastructure. He added that the Kingdom reserves the right to respond at a time and place of its choosing.

The Israeli military also said it intercepted yesterday two drones near the Jordanian border and was investigating where they had been launched from.

The Jordanian army later said that "the Royal Jordanian Air Force aircraft intercepted and shot down, on Monday morning, two drones that had targeted the Kingdom's territory".

Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu has departed for Washington, DC, where he is scheduled to meet US President Donald Trump, according to Israel's Arabic-language account on X.

SEE ALSO P6, P-I, II, III

IN FOCUS



RACE ON TO CONTAIN MONSTER WILDFIRES

Shelters in France and Spain are overflowing with exhausted locals and holidaymakers forced to flee deadly blazes | P8-9

AFP